

Agents are the new SaaS

Greg Isenberg · Greg's Letter · April 29, 2026

Hey friend,

Let's talk about agents are the new SaaS.

Salesforce just went headless. The entire platform — Salesforce, Agentforce, Slack — is now exposed as APIs, MCP, and CLI. Marc Benioff announced it himself. The API is the UI now.

"Welcome Salesforce Headless 360: No Browser Required! Our API is the UI. Entire Salesforce & Agentforce & Slack platforms are now exposed as APIs, MCP, & CLI. All AI agents can access data, workflows, and tasks directly in Slack, Voice, or anywhere else with Salesforce Headless." — Marc Benioff (@Benioff), April 17, 2026

Every SaaS company will follow. HubSpot, Workday, ServiceNow, all of them. Within 18 months, every major SaaS platform will go headless. They have to. Because the new user is an agent making 10,000 API calls a minute.

This is like when electricity went from being sold as a product to being sold as a utility. Once power came out of the wall, anyone could build an appliance. That's what's happening to SaaS right now. The data is coming out of the wall. And anyone can build the agent that plugs into it.

That creates possibly the biggest startup opportunity of the decade. Probably 10,000+ niches. I want to walk through exactly what this looks like, who wins, and how to build one of these companies.

What The Agent-First World Actually Looks Like

Let me paint the picture because I think most people are still thinking about this too abstractly.

A property manager in Dallas today opens AppFolio at 8am. She clicks through 47 lease renewals that are coming due in the next 60 days. She manually pulls each tenant's payment history. She drafts renewal letters in Word, one by one, adjusting the rent increase based on market comps she looked up on Zillow in a separate tab. She sends each letter through DocuSign. She tracks which ones came back signed in a spreadsheet. This takes her about 14 hours a week.

A property manager in Dallas in 18 months wakes up and checks a summary on her phone. Her agent already pulled every lease expiring in the next 60 days, checked each tenant's payment history, researched market comps, drafted personalized renewal letters with the right rent adjustment, sent them through DocuSign, and is tracking signatures in real time. Three tenants already signed overnight. Two need a call because they pushed back on the increase. The agent flagged those and drafted talking points. She makes two phone calls. Her 14 hours became 20 minutes.

That's one niche. One workflow. One vertical. Now multiply that by every boring operational workflow in every boring industry in America. That's the \$1T.

A recruiter in New York today spends Monday morning sourcing candidates on LinkedIn. She finds 30 profiles that might match the role. She writes 30 personalized outreach messages. She schedules interviews with the 5 who responded last week by going back and forth on email 11 times per candidate. She updates the ATS. She preps the hiring manager with a summary of each candidate. By Wednesday, she's exhausted and has moved 2 candidates forward.

A recruiter in New York in 18 months opens her dashboard and sees that her agent sourced 200 candidates overnight, filtered them down to 30 strong matches, sent personalized outreach to each one, and 8 already responded. The agent scheduled interviews with 5 of them based on the hiring manager's calendar. The recruiter's Monday morning is spent having actual conversations with candidates, which is the part she's good at and the part that actually moves the needle. Everything else was handled.

This is the pattern. In every one of these examples, the SaaS platform (AppFolio, LinkedIn, the ATS) becomes the dumb backend. The database. The agent is the new product layer that sits on top, reads the data, makes decisions, takes actions, and surfaces only the things that need a human brain.

The startup IS the agent. The SaaS is just the database.

Why The Incumbents Are Stuck

Think about it like a restaurant. The incumbent SaaS companies spent 20 years building a beautiful dining room. The chairs are perfect. The lighting is perfect. The menu is laminated. They optimized every detail for the human sitting at the table.

Now the new customer is a delivery driver who just needs to pick up the food from the kitchen. The dining room is irrelevant. The kitchen is all that matters. And the kitchen needs a pickup window, not a hostess.

That's what "going headless" means. Salesforce just built the pickup window. Every SaaS company will have to do the same. But here's why the incumbents are stuck: their entire business model, their pricing, their sales team, their customer success org — all of it was built around humans sitting in the dining room. Ripping that out and rebuilding for agents is like asking a sit-down restaurant to become a ghost kitchen overnight. It's possible, but it's painful, slow, and most of them will fumble it.

That fumble is your opportunity as a founder.

How The Economics Change

Outcome-based pricing becomes the default. Nobody pays per seat when the "seat" is an agent. You pay when the lease gets signed. You pay when the claim gets processed. You pay when the candidate gets hired.

Think about how different this is. The old model was like a gym membership. You pay \$50/month whether you show up or not. The new model is like paying a real estate agent. You pay when the house sells. That alignment of incentives changes everything about how software companies grow.

A property management agent that charges \$5 per lease renewed is a no-brainer. The property manager was spending 3 hours doing it manually. \$5 vs 3 hours of her time. The ROI conversation takes 10 seconds.

An insurance claims agent that charges \$10 per claim processed is a no-brainer. The adjuster was spending 45 minutes on data entry per claim. Multiply that by 15 claims a day. The math sells itself.

The margins are better than traditional SaaS. The teams are smaller. There's zero implementation cost because the agent configures itself. And the wildest part: there's zero churn from bad UX because there is no UX. The agent just runs. The human checks results. You churn when the outcomes stop being good, which is a much higher bar than "we got frustrated with the interface."

The first \$1B agent-native company in each vertical will look wildly different from the SaaS it replaced. A team of 8 people running an agent that processes insurance claims for 500 agencies. A team of 5 running a recruiting agent used by 200 staffing firms. Smaller team. Higher margins. The kind of companies that used to require 200 employees and a Series C now require 10 people and a Stripe account.

Who Wins

The winning founders are ex-operators who understand a vertical workflow cold. The code is the easy part. Any developer can connect to an API. The hard part — the part worth \$100M — is knowing that a property manager spends 14 hours a week on lease renewals. Or that an insurance adjuster spends 60% of their day on data entry. Or that a freight broker makes 35 phone calls a day to check on shipment status when the data already exists in three different systems.

That domain knowledge is the real moat. The code is a commodity. The workflow intelligence is the asset. And of course people who can figure out distribution. That's been said ad nauseam on X but it's true.

Here's an example that gets me excited. I know a guy who spent 8 years as an operations manager at a mid-size logistics company. He knows every step of the freight brokerage workflow. He knows that brokers spend 4 hours a day calling carriers to check on loads that are already being tracked by GPS. He knows that the rate negotiation process involves pulling data from 6 different spreadsheets and 3 websites. He knows the exact moment in the workflow where things fall apart because he's lived it.

That guy, with a weekend of coding and an API connection to a TMS, can build an agent that does 70% of a freight broker's daily work. The broker's job becomes relationship management and exception handling. The human parts. Everything else is handled.

He can charge per load. \$3 per load managed. A mid-size brokerage handles 500 loads a month. That's \$1,500/month per customer. Get 200 brokerages and you're at \$300k/month. With a team of 6. Selling to people he already knows.

Compare that to the old playbook: raise \$5M, hire 40 people, build a dashboard, spend 18 months on sales cycles, and hope the enterprise customers actually log in.

The Tactical Playbook

Here's how I'd actually build one of these companies right now.

Step 1: Pick one vertical.

Go narrow. Property management. Dental practices. Freight brokerage. Immigration law. Veterinary clinics. The narrower the better. "AI for small business" is a graveyard. "AI lease renewal agent for mid-market property managers" is a business. The narrower you go, the faster you learn the workflow, the easier it is to sell, and the harder it is for a horizontal player to compete with you.

Step 2: Do the work manually first.

Before you write a line of code, do the job. Be the agent. Handle the lease renewals yourself for a few property managers. Process claims yourself. Source candidates yourself. This is where you find the edge cases that make or break the product. Like the fact that in Texas, lease renewals require a specific 30-day notice format that's different from California. Or that insurance claims involving rental cars have a completely different processing path. You only learn this by doing it. The "we've always done it this way" stuff turns out to be load-bearing.

Step 3: Map the entire workflow.

Draw it out. Every step. Every handoff. Every tool. Every spreadsheet. Every phone call. Every "I check this other thing first" detour. Document all of it. This becomes your product spec and your sales pitch. When you can walk into a property management company and say "I know you spend 14 hours a week on lease renewals, and 6 of those hours are just pulling payment history and drafting letters, because I've done it myself," you've already won the conversation.

Step 4: Build the agent.

Now you code. Connect to the APIs. Build the workflow. Start with the single most painful step in the process and automate that one thing brilliantly. For property management, maybe that's just the lease renewal letter drafting. One step. Make it undeniable. Get 5 customers using it. Then expand to the next step. Then the next. Each step you add makes the product stickier and the customer's life easier.

Step 5: Charge per outcome.

Per lease renewed. Per claim processed. Per candidate hired. Per load managed. This aligns your incentives with the customer and makes the ROI conversation dead simple. "You were paying someone \$35/hour to do this manually. My agent does it for \$5 per transaction. It pays for itself in the first week." I've seen founders overthink pricing for months. Just charge per outcome and iterate.

Step 6: Build distribution through media.

This is the part most technical founders skip and it's the part that matters most now. When anyone can wire agents to APIs, the company with the audience and the brand wins. Media + agents is the new SaaS. This is why Silicon Valley is going all influencer. Roy Lee gets this. Pat Walls gets this. Sam Parr gets this. Build the content engine around your vertical. Post on X about property management. Make YouTube videos about how lease renewals work. Write a newsletter for

property managers. Become the “AI for property management” person. The content is your sales team. Your first 100 customers are sitting in the replies.

Step 7: Expand the workflow.

Once you own one step, expand to the next. Lease renewals become tenant screening become rent collection become maintenance coordination. Now you own the entire property management workflow end-to-end. You went from a tool to an operating system. That’s when you become very hard to displace. That’s when the property manager can’t imagine running their business without you. And that’s when you’ve built something real.

TL;DR

The last wave of SaaS rewarded people who built pretty interfaces on top of ugly data. Beautiful dashboards. Clean onboarding. Smooth UX. That was the moat. The dining room was the product.

This wave rewards people who build smart agents on top of exposed APIs. Or who build the APIs themselves. The kitchen is the product now. The interface is irrelevant. The outcome is everything.

The fastest path to wealth right now: find an industry that still runs on dashboards, phone calls, and spreadsheets. Build the agent-native version. Charge per outcome. Own the workflow end-to-end.

Someone reading this letter right now is going to build a \$100M company off this exact shift. I genuinely believe that. The window is wide open, the APIs are exposed, and most industries are still running the same workflows they had in 2015.

I’m rooting for you.

— Greg Isenberg

Greg’s Bookmarks

#1 — @InternetH0F (April 27, 2026)

“Roblox CEO says that they bought their first 1,500 users from Google for \$1 each. He says that all 300 million of their users stemmed from those original 1,500.”

Greg: Insane story. But I find it hard to believe. Truth is most products aren’t as simple as buy XYZ amount of users and they will “be fruitful and multiply.” It’s more than that.

#2 — @signulll (April 26, 2026)

“Everyone is now able to build computer use agents (e.g. drive your mac to do things). This is now roughly a commodity product. The GUI era as a one-to-many interface will likely end way sooner than people think.”

Greg: This definitely gets me thinking. Good time to be making agents, less good time to be making GUI software.

#3 — @zachpogrob (April 25, 2026)

"Great apps don't make people do something new. They take something we already do and just make it 100x easier/better/cooler. Every time you feel tempted to reinvent, reimagine, and 'invent' a new behavior, be prepared to crawl through hell."

Greg: If you're going to make an app with a graphical user interface (GUI), you probably want to make something like this.

#4 — @BrianNorgard (Dec 2, 2020)

"We overvalue people we don't know and undervalue those we do."

Greg: Good reminder.